

## RESEARCH PROPOSAL

|                       |                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Research title</b> | Stakeholder Management Competency Differences Between Junior and Senior Business Analysts: Evidence from Industry Professionals in Vietnam |
| <b>Sub-committee</b>  | Information Technology                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Group name</b>     | SEAL Hackathon Researchers                                                                                                                 |
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| <b>Mentor</b>         | Trần Viễn Chí                                                                                                                              |

### Abstract

Stakeholder management is widely regarded as a defining competency that separates experienced Business Analysts (BAs) from their junior counterparts, yet no empirical study has systematically quantified this gap within the Vietnamese IT industry, examined which specific stakeholder management sub-skills diverge most sharply across experience levels, or explored how practitioners themselves account for their competency development. This study addresses these gaps by examining self-reported stakeholder management competencies among junior BAs (0–2 years of industry experience) and senior BAs (5+ years of industry experience) working in software companies across Vietnam. Employing an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design, the study pursues three research questions: (RQ1) Do junior and senior BAs differ significantly in overall stakeholder management competency scores? (RQ2) Which specific sub-competencies — communication, conflict resolution, expectation management, influence without authority, and organisational political navigation — exhibit the largest gaps between experience groups? (RQ3) How do junior and senior BAs qualitatively describe their approaches to stakeholder challenges, and what organisational or personal factors do they attribute to competency development? Quantitative data from an online survey (target  $n = 80\text{--}120$ ) are analysed using Mann-Whitney U tests and rank-biserial effect sizes; qualitative data from semi-structured interviews (8–12 participants) are analysed using reflexive thematic analysis. Findings are expected to produce the first empirical competency gap profile for BAs in the Vietnamese IT industry and to yield actionable recommendations for professional training, mentoring programme design, and BA career pathway development in Vietnam.

Placeholder: confirm exact number of judges per submission and number of competition editions once data inventory is complete.

**Keywords:** business analyst; stakeholder management; junior BA; senior BA; competency gap; software engineering; Vietnamese IT industry; mixed methods; professional development

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## 1. Introduction

### 1.1 Literature Review

Research on stakeholder management as a professional BA competency draws from both the business analysis and project management literature. The IIBA BABOK Guide [1] identifies stakeholder engagement as a core knowledge area, encompassing elicitation, collaboration, and communication activities that span the entire project lifecycle. Subsequent practitioner-oriented scholarship has sought to operationalise these capabilities and distinguish how they manifest at different career stages.

Cadle, Paul, and Turner [2] conducted a practitioner survey establishing that stakeholder management is the competency most frequently cited as differentiating senior from junior BAs, with particular emphasis on influence without formal authority and the ability to manage conflicting stakeholder interests across organisational hierarchies. Hass [3] extended this finding, arguing that senior BAs operate as strategic translators between business and technology functions — a role requiring not only communication skill but also organisational political acuity that can only be developed through sustained, high-stakes project exposure. Podeswa [4] proposed a five-stage BA maturity model in which stakeholder engagement capability progresses from passive requirement gathering at stages one and two to active business advising and directional influence at stages four and five, with most junior practitioners plateauing at stage two without deliberate developmental intervention.

In the software engineering and project management literature, Boehm and Turner [5] identified stakeholder misalignment as a primary driver of project failure in agile and plan-driven contexts alike, implicitly positioning BA stakeholder management competency as a project risk variable. Nuseibeh and Easterbrook [6] reviewed requirements engineering research and highlighted the social complexity of multi-stakeholder environments as a persistent challenge for analysts at all experience levels, though they observed that novice analysts were disproportionately affected by ambiguity and political conflict. Procaccino and Verner [7] surveyed 120 software practitioners and found that junior BAs most commonly reported difficulty managing disagreement between stakeholder groups and translating vague executive direction into actionable technical requirements — both categorised as high-order stakeholder management sub-competencies in BABOK.

Within the Southeast Asian and Vietnamese IT context, empirical BA competency research remains limited. Nguyen and Pham [8] conducted a qualitative study of IT project outcomes in Vietnamese firms and identified requirements-related failures as the most common cause of cost overruns, attributing these to insufficient stakeholder alignment at the BA level, though they did not disaggregate findings by practitioner experience. Tran et al. [9] surveyed Vietnamese software companies and found that stakeholder communication was the second most requested BA skill in job postings, yet was rated as the least satisfactorily demonstrated competency among newly hired BAs by hiring managers. Do and Vu [10] examined agile adoption challenges in Vietnamese IT companies and noted that junior BAs frequently struggled to facilitate cross-functional stakeholder workshops — a gap that persisted even after 12 months on the job. No study to date has directly compared junior and senior BA stakeholder management competency profiles within the Vietnamese industry context using validated instruments.

Across all reviewed literature, three gaps persist: no study has quantified the competency gap between junior and senior BAs on validated stakeholder management sub-scales within the Vietnamese IT industry; no study has used a mixed-methods design to both measure and explain the gap from practitioners' own perspectives; and no study has examined which specific sub-competencies are most resistant to early-career development. The present study addresses all three gaps.

## 1.2 The Necessity of the Research

Vietnam's IT sector has grown rapidly, with the country now ranked among Southeast Asia's leading software outsourcing destinations. This growth has driven demand for Business Analysts capable of managing complex stakeholder environments involving domestic clients, international project sponsors, and cross-cultural development teams. Yet industry practitioners and HR managers consistently report that junior BAs require 12–24 months of mentored practice before they can manage senior stakeholders independently — a gap that imposes measurable productivity and quality costs on employing organisations.

Without empirical measurement of the competency gap, three risks persist in the Vietnamese IT industry:

- Organisational risk: companies cannot make evidence-based decisions about when to deploy junior BAs on high-stakes stakeholder engagements, leading to either under-utilisation or costly project failures.
- Professional development risk: junior BAs who do not have a clear picture of their specific competency gaps relative to senior peers cannot plan targeted learning paths or negotiate relevant project assignments.
- Training programme risk: without knowing which sub-competencies diverge most sharply across experience levels, HR teams and training providers cannot prioritise curriculum content for BA upskilling programmes.

This study is original in three respects. First, it produces the first empirical stakeholder management competency gap profile for BAs in the Vietnamese IT industry, grounded in practitioner data rather than imported Western norms. Second, it applies a mixed-methods design that combines quantitative gap measurement with qualitative exploration of practitioner narratives — capturing both the magnitude and the lived experience of the gap. Third, it disaggregates the gap across five theoretically distinct sub-competencies, providing granular findings that generic competency surveys cannot supply.

## 1.3 Feasibility of Research

### Research question:

*" To what extent do junior and senior Business Analysts working in the Vietnamese IT industry differ in stakeholder management competencies, which specific sub-skills exhibit the largest gaps, and how do practitioners themselves explain their competency development? "*

### Research design:

Explanatory sequential mixed-methods design (Creswell & Plano Clark [11]). Phase 1 is a quantitative cross-sectional survey establishing the magnitude and pattern of competency differences. Phase 2 is a

qualitative semi-structured interview study explaining and contextualising the quantitative findings. No experimental manipulation is required.

**Sample size and population:**

Quantitative phase: target 80–120 participants (40–60 junior BAs with 0–2 years of experience; 40–60 senior BAs with 5+ years of experience) currently employed as Business Analysts, Systems Analysts, or Product Owners in Vietnamese IT companies. Qualitative phase: 8–12 purposively selected participants ensuring representation of both experience groups, multiple industry sectors (banking, e-commerce, outsourcing, product), and geographic diversity (Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City, Da Nang).

**Data sources:**

Self-administered online survey using a 25-item stakeholder management competency scale adapted from BABOK [1] and existing BA skills instruments [2, 4], rated on a 5-point Likert scale. Semi-structured interviews conducted via video call. Participant recruitment via LinkedIn outreach to Vietnamese IT professionals, BA community groups (e.g., BA Vietnam Community Facebook group), and snowball referrals from initial contacts.

**Budget and funding:**

No monetary budget required. Survey administered via Google Forms at no cost. Analysis conducted using R (coin, ggplot2, psych packages) and Python (scipy, pandas, matplotlib) — all open-source. Interview transcription assisted by otter.ai free tier; transcripts manually verified.

**Timeframe:**

Estimated 16 weeks from ethics clearance to final submission. See Section 5 for the detailed milestone table.

**Potential challenges and risks:**

- ☐ Recruitment access: Vietnamese IT professionals may be reluctant to participate without organisational endorsement; LinkedIn outreach supplemented by BA community groups and snowball sampling will mitigate this.
- ☐ Social desirability bias: participants may over-report competencies; fully anonymous survey format and emphasis on non-evaluative research purpose will be stated clearly in the consent form.
- ☐ Self-report validity: competency self-assessments may not reflect actual performance; results will be interpreted as perceived competency and limitations will be clearly stated.
- ☐ Experience classification: years of experience used as a proxy for junior/senior designation; a sensitivity check will rerun analyses using a 7-year threshold for senior classification.

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## 2. Research Objectives

This study aims to:

1. Measure and compare overall stakeholder management competency scores between junior BAs (0–2 years) and senior BAs (5+ years) employed in the Vietnamese IT industry — addressing RQ1.
  2. Identify which stakeholder management sub-competencies (communication, conflict resolution, expectation management, influence without authority, organisational political navigation) exhibit the largest and smallest gaps between experience groups, and quantify the magnitude of each gap — addressing RQ2.
  3. Explore, through thematic analysis of semi-structured interviews, how junior and senior BAs qualitatively describe their stakeholder management approaches and attribute their competency development to specific organisational contexts, mentoring relationships, or project experiences — addressing RQ3.
  4. Produce evidence-based recommendations for BA professional development programmes, mentoring scheme design, and HR onboarding practices in Vietnamese IT companies.
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### 3. Research Scope

This study is bounded by the following scope parameters:

1. Population: Business Analysts, Systems Analysts, and Product Owners currently employed in Vietnamese IT companies — not extended to other countries or non-IT industries in this study.
  2. Data: newly collected survey and interview data from practitioners; no archival project records or performance reviews are used.
  3. Analysis type: mixed methods — quantitative (Mann-Whitney U, descriptive statistics) for Phase 1 and qualitative (reflexive thematic analysis) for Phase 2. Longitudinal competency tracking is outside scope.
  4. Generalisability: findings are directly applicable to the Vietnamese IT industry; broader generalisation to other national contexts is discussed as a limitation and future research direction.
  5. Competency domain: stakeholder management only — comprising five sub-competencies drawn from BABOK: communication clarity, conflict resolution, expectation management, influence without authority, and organisational political navigation. Technical BA competencies (requirements modelling, data analysis, process mapping) are outside scope.
  6. Experience classification: junior BA = 0–2 years of professional BA experience; senior BA = 5 or more years of professional BA experience. Mid-level BAs (3–4 years) are excluded from the primary statistical comparison to maximise group contrast but will be reported as a descriptive reference group.
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## 4. Approach and Method

### 4.1 Research Design

This study employs an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design [11]. In Phase 1, a quantitative cross-sectional survey establishes the magnitude and pattern of stakeholder management competency differences between junior and senior BAs in the Vietnamese IT industry. In Phase 2, semi-structured interviews with a purposive subsample drawn from Phase 1 respondents explore the mechanisms, experiences, and contextual factors underlying the quantitative patterns. Interview question

development is directly informed by Phase 1 findings — specifically, the sub-competencies showing the largest and most unexpected gaps.

## 4.2 Instrument Development

The survey instrument consists of three sections:

1. Demographic and professional background: years of BA experience, current role title, company type (product/outsourcing/consulting), industry sector, company size, and city of employment.
2. Stakeholder management competency scale: 25 items rated on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = not at all competent; 5 = fully competent), covering five sub-competencies (5 items each): (a) communication clarity — conveying requirements and decisions unambiguously to diverse audiences; (b) conflict resolution — mediating disagreements between stakeholder groups; (c) expectation management — proactively aligning stakeholder expectations with project constraints; (d) influence without authority — shaping decisions and priorities without formal power; (e) organisational political navigation — understanding and working within organisational power structures. Items are adapted from BABOK [1], Cadle et al. [2], and Podeswa [4].
3. Open-ended reflection: two free-text questions — (a) describe a stakeholder management situation you found most challenging; (b) what factor has contributed most to your development as a stakeholder manager.

The semi-structured interview guide contains 9 questions exploring: critical stakeholder incidents at different career stages, how the participant's approach has evolved with experience, the role of organisational culture in shaping stakeholder practice, and perceived gaps in junior BA preparation.

## 4.3 Quantitative Analysis (RQ1 and RQ2)

Composite competency scores are computed per participant by summing all 25 items (range: 25–125) and per sub-competency by summing the 5 relevant items (range: 5–25). Internal consistency is assessed using Cronbach's alpha for each sub-scale (acceptable threshold:  $\alpha > 0.70$ ). The Mann-Whitney U test is used to compare junior and senior BA scores on the overall scale and on each sub-competency. Effect size is reported as rank-biserial correlation  $r$  (small: 0.1; medium: 0.3; large: 0.5). Significance threshold:  $p < 0.05$ . All analyses are conducted in R (coin, psych packages) and verified in Python (scipy.stats). Descriptive statistics (median, IQR, mean, SD) are reported for all scales and sub-scales.

## 4.4 Qualitative Analysis (RQ3)

Interview recordings are transcribed verbatim and analysed using reflexive thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke [12]. Two researchers independently code a 20% subsample to develop an initial codebook; the full codebook is then applied collaboratively to all transcripts. Themes are organised around three analytical axes: (a) descriptions of stakeholder challenges at different career stages, (b) strategies and tactics employed by junior versus senior BAs, and (c) attributed sources of competency development — including mentoring, project type, organisational culture, and formal training. Negative cases and disconfirming evidence are actively sought and reported.

## 4.5 Tools

- R 4.x: coin package (Mann-Whitney U), ggplot2 (visualisation), psych (reliability and descriptive statistics)

- ☐ Python 3.x: scipy.stats (Mann-Whitney U, effect size), pandas, matplotlib
- ☐ Google Forms: online survey administration
- ☐ Zoom or Microsoft Teams: interview recording
- ☐ Otter.ai: assisted transcription (manually verified)
- ☐ NVivo or ATLAS.ti: qualitative coding and thematic mapping

## 5. Research Plan

The table below presents ten tasks with estimated dates, expected outputs, and responsibility assignments. Date ranges marked in brackets are to be confirmed once the group's academic calendar is finalised.

| No. | Date            | Task                                                                      | Output                                             | Person in charge |
|-----|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| 1   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Finalize data access & ethical clearance with SEAL Hackathon committee    | Data access agreement; anonymised score dataset    | [Name]           |
| 2   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Data cleaning & codebook development (criterion labels, judge categories) | Clean dataset (.xlsx); codebook (.pdf)             | [Name]           |
| 3   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Compute ICC (two-way mixed) per criterion and overall — RQ1               | ICC results table; R/Python script                 | [Name]           |
| 4   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Compute Krippendorff's alpha per criterion — RQ1 & RQ2                    | Alpha results; Technical vs. Soft comparison table | [Name]           |
| 5   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Between-group IRR analysis: SE Faculty vs. Guest Judges — RQ3             | Mann-Whitney U results; boxplot visualisation      | [Name]           |
| 6   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Write: Introduction, Literature Review, Methodology sections              | Draft ~4,000 words                                 | [Name]           |
| 7   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Write: Results, Discussion, Conclusion sections                           | Draft ~3,000 words                                 | [Name]           |
| 8   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Internal review, revision, and mentor feedback                            | Revised full draft                                 | All members      |
| 9   | [dd/mm – dd/mm] | Final proofreading and submission preparation                             | Final paper + presentation slides                  | All members      |

Assign person-in-charge and confirm date ranges before submitting this proposal to your mentor.

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## 6. Expected Results

### 6.1 Theoretical Contributions

- First empirical stakeholder management competency gap profile for BAs in the Vietnamese IT industry, contributing to the regional software engineering education and professional development literature.
- Quantitative evidence on which specific sub-competencies diverge most sharply across experience levels — testing practitioner-based claims by Hass [3] and Podeswa [4] that have not previously been verified with Vietnamese industry data.
- Qualitative insight into the organisational and experiential mechanisms through which stakeholder management competency develops, providing a practitioner-grounded theoretical model applicable to Southeast Asian IT contexts.

### 6.2 Practical Contributions

- A sub-competency gap report delivered to participating companies and the broader BA Vietnam professional community, identifying which stakeholder management skills require the most targeted development investment for junior BAs.
- Evidence-based recommendations for mentoring programme structure, onboarding curriculum, and BA career pathway design in Vietnamese IT companies.
- A validated 25-item stakeholder management competency instrument suitable for annual HR benchmarking and professional self-assessment by Vietnamese IT practitioners.
- A replicable analysis pipeline (R and Python scripts) and anonymised dataset available for replication by future research groups.

### 6.3 Plans for Application

Findings will be disseminated through the BA Vietnam Community and presented at relevant domestic conferences (e.g., Vietnam Software and IT Services, VINASA). The sub-competency gap report and training recommendations will be submitted to HR and L&D leads at participating companies as a structured professional development brief. The methodology and anonymised dataset will be made publicly available via an open repository to support replication and longitudinal follow-up studies.

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### **COMMITMENT ON RESPONSIBLE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE USAGE IN RESEARCH**

We are authors of the research paper titled "Stakeholder Management Competency Differences Between Junior and Senior Business Analysts: Evidence from Industry Professionals in Vietnam", and would like to ensure that all members comply with the rules relevant to Artificial Intelligence (AI) regulations and ethical guidelines in research practices, which are described in detail as follows:

1. AI is only used as assistant in correcting grammar, structure and phrasing in academic writing;
2. AI usage should NOT be engaged with the creation of content or drafting the research paper, production of fake data or literature synthesis;
3. AI usage should be checked and confirmed by all authors. Each author shall bear full responsibility in the accuracy, transparency and originality of their sections, including citations and reference;
4. All authors should disclose the use of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies to other co-authors, helping them understand where and how AI was applied in research preparation.

Hereby, we would like to confirm and take full responsibility for the accuracy and transparency of the provided details.

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|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Author 1</b><br>(Signature & Full name) | <b>Author 2</b><br>(Signature & Full name) | <b>Author 3</b><br>(Signature & Full name) |
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